

CONTROLLING OFFICER'S REPLY**HHB196****(Question Serial No. 2836)**Head: (37) Department of HealthSubhead (No. & title): (-) Not SpecifiedProgramme: (2) Disease PreventionControlling Officer: Director of Health (Dr. Ronald LAM)Director of Bureau: Secretary for HealthQuestion:

Regarding the refinement of the Elderly Health Care Voucher Scheme (EHVS), please advise on:

1. the number of eligible beneficiaries under the EHVS and the total expenditure on the scheme in each of the past 3 years, as well as the estimated expenditure for 2026-27;
2. the number of voucher accounts with a zero balance on 31 December in each of the past 3 years;
3. the number of voucher claim transactions, the amount claimed and the average, median as well as the maximum and minimum amount claimed per transaction in the past 3 years, broken down by type of healthcare service provider;
4. the number of healthcare service providers enrolled under the EHVS and their participation rates, broken down by type of healthcare service provider; and
5. the respective numbers of complaints received, with investigation completed and found to be substantiated by the Department of Health in relation to Elderly Health Care Vouchers (broken down by type of healthcare service provider and nature of complaint) and, among them, the number of healthcare service providers or voucher recipients disqualified from the EHVS and the number of cases with prosecution instigated in the past 3 years.

Asked by: Hon CHAN Hoi-yan (LegCo internal reference no.: 18)

Reply:

1. and 2.

The number of elderly persons eligible for the Elderly Health Care Voucher Scheme (EHVS) and the number of elderly persons with a zero-balance Elderly Health Care Voucher (EHCV) account by the end of the year over the past 3 years are tabulated below:

	2023	2024	2025
Number of eligible elderly persons (i.e. elderly persons aged 65 or above)*	1 638 000	1 702 000	1 783 000
Number of elderly persons with a zero-balance EHCV account by the end of the year	313 000	353 000	380 000

* According to the information from the Hong Kong Population Projections 2022-2046 of the Census and Statistics Department

The actual/estimated expenditures on the EHVS for the financial years from 2023-24 to 2026-27 are as follows:

Year	Actual/estimated expenditure on the EHVS (\$ billion)
2023-24	3.33 (Actual)
2024-25	3.42 (Actual)
2025-26	3.68 (Revised estimate)
2026-27	4.25 (Estimate)

3.

The tables below show the number of voucher claim transactions, the amount of vouchers claimed and the average, median, maximum and minimum amounts per claim transaction under the EHVS (including the Elderly Health Care Voucher Greater Bay Area Pilot Scheme (Pilot Scheme)) by types of healthcare service provider/medical institution in the Greater Bay Area (GBA) enrolled in the EHVS in the past 3 years:

Number of Voucher Claim Transactions

	2023 ^{Note 1}	2024	2025
Healthcare service providers in Hong Kong			
Medical Practitioners	2 325 617	2 444 952	2 364 586
Chinese Medicine Practitioners	1 965 635	2 160 315	2 282 291
Dentists	331 342	331 567	332 806
Occupational Therapists	4 232	3 003	3 322
Physiotherapists	45 673	43 341	42 277
Medical Laboratory Technologists	15 441	14 503	15 275
Radiographers	22 659	23 285	23 374
Nurses	11 196	10 800	12 587
Chiropractors	10 331	8 724	8 339
Optometrists	230 239	175 563	199 203
Audiologists ^{Note 2}	784	1 636	1 937
Clinical Psychologists ^{Note 2}	2	-	4
Dietitians ^{Note 2}	609	1 356	1 080
Speech Therapists ^{Note 2}	5	7	42
Sub-total (Hong Kong):	4 963 765	5 219 052	5 287 123
Medical institutions in the GBA^{Note 3}	38 462	77 918	153 051
Total:	5 002 227	5 296 970	5 440 174

Amount of Vouchers Claimed (in HK\$'000)

	2023 ^{Note 1}	2024	2025
Healthcare service providers in Hong Kong			
Medical Practitioners	1,270,495	1,363,308	1,371,198
Chinese Medicine Practitioners	1,140,988	1,227,911	1,369,438
Dentists	413,222	402,347	394,346
Occupational Therapists	4,455	3,404	2,454
Physiotherapists	22,726	23,083	23,880
Medical Laboratory Technologists	14,712	13,353	12,870
Radiographers	29,503	34,556	35,804
Nurses	11,168	10,427	11,039
Chiropractors	5,955	5,467	5,383
Optometrists	352,743	255,505	298,434
Audiologists ^{Note 2}	2,693	5,040	5,473
Clinical Psychologists ^{Note 2}	4	-	12
Dietitians ^{Note 2}	829	1,110	1,391
Speech Therapists ^{Note 2}	5	7	55
Sub-total (Hong Kong):	3,269,498	3,345,518	3,531,777
Medical institutions in the GBA^{Note 3}	11,883	39,339	82,186
Total:	3,281,381	3,384,857	3,613,963

Average Amount of Vouchers per Claim Transaction (HK\$)

	2023 ^{Note 1}	2024	2025
Healthcare service providers in Hong Kong			
Medical Practitioners	546	558	580
Chinese Medicine Practitioners	580	568	600
Dentists	1,247	1,213	1,185
Occupational Therapists	1,053	1,134	739
Physiotherapists	498	533	565
Medical Laboratory Technologists	953	921	843
Radiographers	1,302	1,484	1,532
Nurses	997	965	877
Chiropractors	576	627	646
Optometrists	1,532	1,455	1,498
Audiologists ^{Note 2}	3,435	3,081	2,826
Clinical Psychologists ^{Note 2}	2,000	N/A	3,000
Dietitians ^{Note 2}	1,361	819	1,288
Speech Therapists ^{Note 2}	1,000	1,000	1,310
Medical institutions in the GBA^{Notes 3 and 4}	309	505	537

Median Amount of Vouchers per Claim Transaction (HK\$)

	2023 ^{Note 1}	2024	2025
Healthcare service providers in Hong Kong			
Medical Practitioners	400	410	430
Chinese Medicine Practitioners	320	324	340
Dentists	835	800	800
Occupational Therapists	300	300	150
Physiotherapists	320	350	380
Medical Laboratory Technologists	720	700	620
Radiographers	800	900	910
Nurses	500	490	390
Chiropractors	560	600	620
Optometrists	1,880	1,748	1,820
Audiologists ^{Note 2}	2,121	1,905	1,618
Clinical Psychologists ^{Note 2}	1,800	N/A	2,900
Dietitians ^{Note 2}	1,105	310	380
Speech Therapists ^{Note 2}	1,200	1,000	1,300
Medical institutions in the GBA ^{Notes 3 and 4}	114	186	170

Range of Maximum and Minimum Voucher Amounts per Claim Transaction (HK\$)

	Range of Maximum Voucher Amounts per Claim Transaction (HK\$) ^{Note 5}		
	2023 ^{Note 1}	2024	2025
Healthcare service providers in Hong Kong			
Medical Practitioners	>8,000	>8,000	>8,000
Chinese Medicine Practitioners	>8,000	>8,000	>8,000
Dentists	>8,000	>8,000	>8,000
Occupational Therapists	7,751 – 8,000	7,751 – 8,000	6,251 – 6,500
Physiotherapists	>8,000	>8,000	>8,000
Medical Laboratory Technologists	7,751 – 8,000	7,751 – 8,000	>8,000
Radiographers	>8,000	>8,000	>8,000
Nurses	>8,000	>8,000	>8,000
Chiropractors	6,001 – 6,250	7,751 – 8,000	6,251 – 6,500
Optometrists	1,751 – 2,000	1,751 – 2,000	1,751 – 2,000
Audiologists ^{Note 2}	>8,000	>8,000	>8,000
Clinical Psychologists ^{Note 2}	1,751 – 2,000	N/A	4,251 – 4,500
Dietitians ^{Note 2}	7,751 – 8,000	4,751 – 5,000	7,751 – 8,000
Speech Therapists ^{Note 2}	1,251 – 1,500	1,751 – 2,000	6,501 – 6,750
Medical institutions in the GBA ^{Notes 3 and 4}	7,251 – 7,500	>8,000	>8,000

	Range of Minimum Voucher Amounts per Claim Transaction (HK\$)		
	2023^{Note 1}	2024	2025
Healthcare service providers in Hong Kong			
Medical Practitioners	1 – 250	1 – 250	1 – 250
Chinese Medicine Practitioners	1 – 250	1 – 250	1 – 250
Dentists	1 – 250	1 – 250	1 – 250
Occupational Therapists	1 – 250	1 – 250	1 – 250
Physiotherapists	1 – 250	1 – 250	1 – 250
Medical Laboratory Technologists	1 – 250	1 – 250	1 – 250
Radiographers	1 – 250	1 – 250	1 – 250
Nurses	1 – 250	1 – 250	1 – 250
Chiropractors	1 – 250	1 – 250	1 – 250
Optometrists	1 – 250	1 – 250	1 – 250
Audiologists ^{Note 2}	1 – 250	1 – 250	1 – 250
Clinical Psychologists ^{Note 2}	1,751 – 2,000	N/A	1,501 – 1,750
Dietitians ^{Note 2}	1 – 250	1 – 250	1 – 250
Speech Therapists ^{Note 2}	501 – 750	1 – 250	1 – 250
Medical institutions in the GBA^{Notes 3 and 4}	1 - 250	1 - 250	1 - 250

Note 1: Starting from 28 July 2023, the EHVS allows shared use of vouchers between 2 eligible elderly persons in spousal relationship upon their mutual consent and completion of procedures to pair up their voucher accounts. Furthermore, a three-year Elderly Health Care Voucher Pilot Reward Scheme (Pilot Reward Scheme) was launched under the EHVS on 13 November 2023.

Note 2: Since 28 April 2023, the coverage of the EHVS has been extended to include primary healthcare services provided by 4 categories of healthcare professions under the Accredited Registers Scheme for Healthcare Professions (AR Scheme) (namely audiologists, clinical psychologists, dietitians and speech therapists).

Note 3: Including the University of Hong Kong-Shenzhen Hospital and its offsite medical institution, i.e. Huawei Li Zhi Yuan Community Health Service Center, as well as the 19 pilot medical institutions under the Pilot Scheme.

Note 4: Under the existing EHVS, registered private healthcare professionals in Hong Kong may enrol in the scheme as healthcare service providers on an individual basis, while medical institutions in the GBA participate in the scheme on a hospital/medical institution basis. Eligible elderly persons may use EHCVs to pay for the fee of outpatient healthcare services, such as physical examination, continuous preventive healthcare and chronic disease management, etc., provided by the designated departments at medical institutions in the GBA, and the statistics on the related healthcare services are compiled on the basis of services as provided by the respective designated departments, rather than individual healthcare professions. As such, any direct comparison between the average and median amounts of vouchers per claim transaction for healthcare service providers in Hong Kong and those of medical institutions in the GBA is not appropriate. Nor do the figures reflect the levels of primary healthcare service charges of either region.

Note 5: Due to the shared use of vouchers between spouses under the EHVS starting from 28 July 2023 and the \$500 reward under the Pilot Reward Scheme launched on 13 November in

the same year (see Note 1 above) is not subject to the accumulation limit, the maximum voucher amount per claim transaction may exceed \$8,000.

4.

The table below shows the number and participation rate of healthcare service providers in Hong Kong enrolled in the EHVS as at the end of 2025, by types of profession:

Healthcare Service Providers	Number (Participation Rate ^{Note 1})
Medical Practitioners	3 533 (56%)
Chinese Medicine Practitioners	4 752 (62%)
Dentists	1 444 (67%)
Occupational Therapists	155 (9%)
Physiotherapists	759 (28%)
Medical Laboratory Technologists	56 (4%)
Radiographers	76 (6%)
Nurses	509 (2%)
Chiropractors	177 (61%)
Optometrists	954 (89%)
Audiologists ^{Note 2}	43 (62%)
Clinical Psychologists ^{Note 2}	14 (3%)
Dietitians ^{Note 2}	58 (35%)
Speech Therapists ^{Note 2}	41 (13%)
Total:	12 571

Note 1: In calculating the EHVS participation rate of the first 10 types of healthcare service providers (i.e. medical practitioners, Chinese medicine practitioners, dentists, occupational therapists, physiotherapists, medical laboratory technologists, radiographers, nurses, chiropractors and optometrists), those healthcare professionals practising in the public sector or are economically inactive (e.g. not practising in Hong Kong) have been excluded.

Note 2: Since 28 April 2023, the coverage of the EHVS has been extended to include primary healthcare services provided by 4 categories of healthcare professions under the AR Scheme (namely audiologists, clinical psychologists, dietitians and speech therapists). In calculating the percentage of participating healthcare service providers of these 4 professions under the EHVS, the numbers of registrants on the registers of the relevant healthcare professional bodies accredited under the AR Scheme of the Government have been used.

5.

To ensure the proper use of public money, the Department of Health (DH) adopts a robust monitoring mechanism for checking and auditing voucher claims under the EHVS. The relevant measures and procedures include routine checking, monitoring and investigating in respect of aberrant transactions, and investigation into complaints. The DH adopts a risk-based approach to check voucher claims, targeting healthcare service providers who have records of non-compliance with the terms and conditions of the EHVS Agreement and those whose voucher claims show aberrant patterns.

The table below shows the number of complaints (including media reports and relevant intelligence) against healthcare service providers enrolled in the EHVS received by the DH from 2023 to 2025:

	2023	2024	2025	Total
Number of complaints against healthcare service providers enrolled in the EHVS received by the DH	54	88	97	239

These complaint cases, involving operational procedures, suspected fraud, improper voucher claims and issues related to service charges, were mainly against Chinese medicine practitioners, medical practitioners, optometrists and dentists. The DH would conduct investigation into every complaint received and take appropriate actions/measures when violation of the terms and conditions of the EHVS Agreement was found, including issuing advisory/warning letters to the relevant healthcare service providers, withholding reimbursements or recovering paid reimbursements, disqualifying healthcare service providers from participating in the EHVS, and referring cases to the Police and the relevant professional regulatory boards/councils for follow-up as appropriate.

Among the complaint cases against healthcare service providers enrolled under the EHVS received by the DH in the past 3 years, as at end-December 2025, investigation of 128 cases was completed, of which 28 were found to be substantiated or partially substantiated. The DH has disqualified 3 healthcare service providers from participating in the EHVS and has referred 12 cases to the Police for follow-up (of which the investigation of 3 cases was completed with no prosecutions made and 9 cases are still under investigation).

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